

Philosophical Foundations — Module 03: Perception

— Study Questions

1. How does Husserl's intentionality relate to generative models? What is the parallel between "consciousness of" and "prediction about"?
2. Explain Heidegger's ready-to-hand/present-at-hand distinction. How does this map onto prediction error dynamics?
3. How does Merleau-Ponty's embodied perception anticipate Active Inference's sensorimotor coupling?
4. Define "transparency" and "opacity" in phenomenological terms. Give a concrete example of each.
5. What triggers the shift from transparent to opaque experience? Use the hammer example.
6. State the positions of direct realism and indirect realism. Where does Active Inference fall?
7. What is "cybernetic realism" or "enacted directness"? How does it mediate between direct and indirect realism?
8. How does prediction error relate to subjective surprise? Are they the same thing?
9. How does Seth's interoceptive inference account explain emotional experience?
10. What is the phenomenology of curiosity? How does it relate to epistemic value?
11. How does Active Inference explain anxiety? What role does precision play?
12. If perception is "controlled hallucination," how do we distinguish perception from illusion?
13. What is the illusion problem? How does Active Inference address it without invoking a "view from nowhere"?
14. Compare the predictive processing account of perception with Gibson's ecological approach.
15. How does temporal depth in the generative model relate to Husserl's concept of "protention" (anticipation of the future)?
16. How does the concept of precision relate to Husserl's "attentional modification"?
17. Can Active Inference account for aesthetic experience? How?
18. How does the breakdown of prediction relate to Kuhn's paradigm shifts in science?

19. Does Active Inference support phenomenal externalism (experience extends beyond the skull)?
20. Critically evaluate: Does connecting Active Inference to phenomenology genuinely advance either field, or is it a superficial analogy?